

Life of a Deal

Milestone Map — Intelligent Project Schedule

Revision:	Rev 1 — draft
Date:	July 22, 2026
Company:	Central Millwork
Sources:	<i>Life of a Deal 2026 Rev0</i> (41 pp.) + current system + 3-Week Lookahead template
Scope:	53 milestones · 8 phases · 8 hard gates
Under review by:	CEO · PM · Chali Herrera

Changes Rev 0 → Rev 1 (from notes on the printout):

- **Quote phase removed** — the project's life begins at the contract. From 9 to 8 phases.
- **Contract** — the deposit no longer blocks; MTO and budget are *validated*; the kickoff is a complete project review.
- **Engineering** — reordered to 12 milestones; the design call (E-01) absorbs long leads, early procurement, samples, schedule review and estimate validation as sub-tasks; "Change orders" removed; schedule review becomes risk management.
- **Production** — the 3-Week Lookahead is **generated by the system** as a form.

This is not a software plan. It is Central Millwork's own process, written as a chain of milestones.

What this review needs: correct the **durations** (they are estimates), confirm the **owner** of each milestone, and flag the milestones that are **missing, unnecessary, or that don't actually work this way in practice**. Every table has a blank column on the right for handwritten notes.

CEO — name, signature and date

PM — name, signature and date

Chali Herrera — date

Design principles

The seven rules that govern the entire system. If any one of them is rejected, the design changes.

#	Principle	What it means	Notes / objections
P1	The target date is sacred	The delivery date committed to the client is never recalculated automatically . Internal dates and the projection are recalculated. When the projection passes the target date, the project turns red — the date does not move. Moving it is a recorded human decision: who, when, why, how many days.	
P2	No milestone closes on a claim — it closes on evidence	There is no “it’s done” checkbox. Every milestone closes because the artifact that proves it appeared (a file, a submittal, a client click, a station move), and the system sets the date , not the person.	
P3	The record is a by-product of the work	The drawing submittal goes out from the system, so the date records itself. If someone has to perform an extra task just to report, that design is wrong and will be abandoned within three weeks.	
P4	Progress is counted, not estimated	No human-typed “% complete”. Progress is evidenced sub-milestones completed over total. If it cannot be counted, it is not displayed.	
P5	Two clocks	Backward from the delivery date: the deadline for each milestone. Forward from actual events: where we are going to land. The gap between them is float . Negative float = risk of missing the date.	
P6	The system pushes early, it does not explain late	A schedule that only absorbs delays is a scoreboard of losses. Every milestone approaching its deadline alerts its owner beforehand , and automatically reminds the client when the ball is in their court.	
P7	Whoever arrives last holds the ball	When a milestone has several predecessors, its actual start is the latest of them . The system names which one it was and how many days it cost. No argument.	

The journey

CONTRACT → ENGINEERING → MATERIALS → PRODUCTION → QC → SHIPPING → INSTALL → COMPLETED

The target delivery date is entered when the project is created (Contract phase). There the system calculates backward and says whether it is born achievable or already at risk — that calculation is the feasibility check. The **operational day zero** is contract execution (C-03).

Assembly is not a phase. In the official document it appears only as a shop stage inside *Manufacture* (p.33) and *Quality Control* (p.34). Station-level detail is already tracked by the Production module to the minute.

Legend — **HAVE** data already exists · **PART** partial, the formal dated event is missing · **NEW** must be built | **GATE** blocks another phase · **CONT** continuous/recurring · **COND** conditional

1 CONTRACT

Phase owner: **Estimator** → handoff to **PM / Engineer**. When the project is created, the **required completion date** (the schedule anchor) is entered.

#	Milestone	Owner	Dur.	Depends on	Evidence that closes it	Today	Notes / correction
C-01	Project in negotiation	Estimator	—	—	Stage change in the pipeline (p.6)	NEW	
C-02	Contract reviewed / addendum issued	Estimator	3-10 d	C-01	Reviewed contract PDF + addendum attached (p.6)	NEW	
C-03	CONTRACT EXECUTED — day zero	Estimator + CFO	—	C-02	Signed PDF uploaded to the project (p.6)	NEW	
C-04	Material deposit received (non-blocking)	Office Manager	5-15 d	C-03	Payment recorded with amount and date (p.18)	NEW	
C-05	Preliminary MTO validated	Estimator	1-2 d	C-03	Preliminary MTO imported and validated (quantities, scope) (p.7)	PART	
C-06	Project budget validated	Estimator	1 d	C-03	Budget loaded by area and validated (p.8)	NEW	
C-07	Project announcement sent	Estimator	1 d	C-05, C-06	Email triggered from the system + project folder created with all documents (p.9)	NEW	
C-08	Kickoff = complete project review	Estimator + Eng + PM	1 d	C-07	Complete review with GC and designer recorded + notes distributed from the system (p.10)	NEW	
C-09	POC transferred to Engineer / PM	Estimator	—	C-08	Handoff email triggered from the system (p.11)	NEW	

C-03 is operational day zero. The deposit (C-04) is still recorded but **no longer blocks**: the company proceeds without an initial deposit. The underlying principle: if the contract is signed late everything shifts, but the real failure is letting time pass without it being signed — that is why C-02/C-03 alert beforehand.

2 ENGINEERING

Phase owner: **Engineer** (PM support) — the largest phase, and the one that exposes the most delay

#	Milestone	Type	Owner	Dur.	Depends on	Evidence that closes it	Today	Notes / correction
E-01	Design call / engineering kickoff		Engineer	1-2 d	C-08	Design meeting with designer and GC + notes; includes the 5 sub-tasks below (p.13)	NEW	
↳ E-01a	<i>Long lead times identified</i>	GATE	Engineer + PM	2-3 d	—	Materials flagged as long-lead with lead time reconfirmed by the vendor (p.12)	PART	
↳ E-01b	<i>Early procurement approved by client</i>	GATE	PM	3-10 d	—	Client approval through the portal (p.12)	NEW	
↳ E-01c	<i>Finish samples requested from client</i>		Engineer	1 d	—	Sample created with committed date (p.17)	HAVE	
↳ E-01d	<i>Schedule review</i>		Engineer + PM	—	—	Project schedule reviewed with risks flagged (p.15)	NEW	
↳ E-01e	<i>Estimate validated</i>		Engineer	—	—	Estimate / preliminary MTO validated against project documents	NEW	
E-02	V/E options proposed to client	COND	Engineer + PM	3-5 d	E-01	Options sent + client response recorded (p.14)	NEW	
E-03	VIF / field measurements	COND	Field Specialist	1-2 d	E-01	Measurements and photos uploaded from the mobile app with date and location (p.21)	NEW	
E-04	Samples fabricated and shipped		Shop Manager	10-14 d	E-01c	Shipment recorded with photo of the package (p.17)	HAVE	
E-05	Samples approved by client	GATE	Engineer	5-15 d	E-04	Client approval through the portal (p.17)	PART	
E-06	Shop drawings submitted to client		Engineer	10-25 d	E-01, E-03	Submittal generated and sent from the system with PDF attached (p.19)	NEW	

#	Milestone	Type	Owner	Dur.	Depends on	Evidence that closes it	Today	Notes / correction
E-07	Shop drawings approved by client	GATE	Engineer	10-20 d	E-06	Approve / Approve as noted / Reject in the portal, with date and identity (<i>p.19, p.20</i>)	NEW	
E-08	Comments incorporated and resubmitted	COND	Engineer	3-10 d	E-07	New revision issued from the system (<i>p.20</i>)	NEW	
E-09	Final MTO released to purchasing	GATE	Engineer	2-5 d	E-07	Updated MTO flagged as released (<i>p.18</i>)	PART	
E-10	Release to Production	GATE	Engineer	1 d	E-07	"Approved"-stamped drawings attached + release email triggered from the system (<i>p.22</i>)	NEW	
E-11	CNC files delivered	GATE	Engineer	2-5 d	E-10	CNC files uploaded and linked to the production order (<i>p.29</i>)	NEW	
E-12	Risk management (can the deadline be met?)	CONT	Engineer + PM	weekly	—	Schedule review recorded: can the deadline be met? Risks flagged and communicated to the client (<i>p.15</i>)	NEW	

Removed in Rev 1: "Change orders communicated" as a milestone. COs are still managed, but are not a milestone on the journey; their impact on the target date remains to be defined. **E-09 no longer depends on the deposit** (C-04): only on approved shop drawings (E-07).

3 MATERIALS

Phase owner: **Procurement Manager** — the best instrumented phase today

#	Milestone	Type	Owner	Dur.	Depends on	Evidence that closes it	Today	Notes / correction
M-01	Procurement schedule review (<i>risk management</i>)	CONT	Procurement Mgr	weekly	C-07	Review recorded: at-risk materials flagged and communicated to PM and Production (<i>p.23</i>)	NEW	
M-02	Material budget validated		Procurement Mgr	2-3 d	E-09	Validation against the estimate recorded, with discrepancies resolved (<i>p.24</i>)	NEW	
M-03	Long-lead items ordered	GATE	Procurement Mgr	1-3 d	E-01b	PO issued (<i>p.25</i>)	HAVE	
M-04	MTO quoted		Procurement Mgr	5-10 d	E-09	Quotes received by vendor (<i>p.26</i>)	HAVE	
M-05	POs issued		Procurement Mgr	2-3 d	M-04, M-02	POs generated with ETA per vendor (<i>p.26</i>)	HAVE	
M-06	POs to subcontractors	COND	PM + CFO	5-10 d	E-10	PO signed by the subcontractor (<i>p.27</i>)	NEW	
M-07	Material received and stocked 100%	GATE	Procurement Mgr	lead time	M-05	All receipts closed, no open shortages (<i>p.28</i>)	HAVE	

M-07 is usually the critical path milestone. The slowest vendor's lead time drives the entire delivery date. This is precisely why the schedule is calculated backward: to know *when the PO must be issued*, not *how long until it arrives*.

4 PRODUCTION

Phase owner: **Production Manager**

#	Milestone	Type	Owner	Dur.	Depends on	Evidence that closes it	Today	Notes / correction
P-01	PRODUCTION INTAKE compound gate	GATE	Production Mgr	1 d	E-05 + E-07 + E-10 + E-11 + M-07	All 5 requirements verified green. The system will not allow production to open without them (<i>p.30</i>)	NEW	
P-02	Distribute to production		Production Controller	1 d	P-01	Production orders created with drawings and MTO linked, CNC delivered to the operator (<i>p.29</i>)	PART	
P-03	Labor budget validated		Production Mgr	1 d	P-01	Budgeted vs. planned hours, risks reported to PM (<i>p.32</i>)	NEW	
P-04	3-Week Lookahead — system-generated form	CONT	PM + Production Mgr	weekly	P-01	The system generates the “3 Week Lookahead” form (see last section) auto-populated and shares it company-wide (<i>p.31</i>)	NEW	
P-05	Fabrication in progress	CONT	Production Team	10-30 d	P-02	Actual progress by station and by item — already tracked by the shop kiosk (<i>p.33</i>)	HAVE	
P-06	Fabrication complete		Production Mgr	—	P-05	All project items at final station (<i>p.33</i>)	HAVE	

P-01 is the heart of the dependency engine. It is the *Production Intake* rule from page 30 turned into a hard gate. Its actual date is **the latest of its 5 predecessors**, and the system names which one it was. Today, when production can’t start, the argument is “I sent the drawings” versus “the material never arrived”. With this, there is data instead.

5 QC

Phase owner: **Production Assistant**

#	Milestone	Type	Owner	Dur.	Depends on	Evidence that closes it	Today	Notes / correction
QC-01	In-process quality checks	CONT	Production Assistant	—	P-05	Inspections recorded at assembly, laminate and paint stages (<i>p.34</i>)	HAVE	
QC-02	Final QC approved	GATE	Production Assistant	1-3 d	P-06	Final inspection with photos of every item (<i>p.34</i>)	HAVE	
QC-03	Rework on defect	COND	Production Mgr	variable	QC-01/02	Rework decision recorded with target station and days lost (<i>p.34</i>)	HAVE	

6 SHIPPING

Phase owner: **Logistics Manager**

#	Milestone	Type	Owner	Dur.	Depends on	Evidence that closes it	Today	Notes / correction
S-01	Packaging complete		Production Team	1-3 d	QC-02	Items tagged with project / item / sequence, matched against the shipping list (<i>p.35</i>)	PART	
S-02	Delivery request issued (48 h)	GATE	PM	—	S-01	Request sent to Logistics and Production with at least 48 hours' notice (<i>p.38</i>)	NEW	
S-03	Transportation confirmed + BOL		Logistics Mgr	1-2 d	S-02	Truck confirmed and BOL issued (<i>p.36</i>)	NEW	
S-04	Shipped		Logistics Mgr	1 d	S-03	Load photos, seal number and signed BOL uploaded (<i>p.36</i>)	NEW	
S-05	Site receiving coordinated	COND	Field Specialist	—	S-04	Coordination with the installer recorded. Not applicable on projects without installation (<i>p.37</i>)	NEW	

7 INSTALL

Phase owner: **Field Specialist** (PM support)

#	Milestone	Type	Owner	Dur.	Depends on	Evidence that closes it	Today	Notes / correction
I-01	Installation dates coordinated	GATE	PM	3-5 d	QC-02	Dates agreed with the installer and communicated to the client (<i>p.38</i>)	NEW	
I-02	Installation materials purchased	GATE	Procurement Mgr	2-5 d	I-01	Installer list received and PO issued, 48 h in advance (<i>p.38</i>)	PART	
I-03	Site ready for installation	GATE	PM	—	—	GC confirmation. External dependency — outside our control	NEW	
I-04	Installation started		Field Specialist	—	S-05, I-02, I-03	On-site check-in from the mobile app (<i>p.40</i>)	NEW	
I-05	Installation in progress	CONT	Field Specialist	5-20 d	I-04	Daily progress by area from the mobile app (<i>p.40</i>)	NEW	
I-06	Punch list closed	GATE	Field Specialist	3-10 d	I-05	Every punch list item with a photo of the resolution (<i>p.40</i>)	NEW	
I-07	Client sign-off		PM	—	I-06	Final client approval through the portal	NEW	

I-03 is the GC's external dependency. When the site is not ready, the delay **does not belong to Central Millwork**, and the system records it with that attribution — the documented record for GC conversations.

8 COMPLETED

Phase owner: **PM + CFO**

#	Milestone	Owner	Dur.	Depends on	Evidence that closes it	Today	Notes / correction
X-01	Internal closeout report	PM	2-3 d	I-07	Report with feedback and photos uploaded (<i>p.39</i>)	NEW	
X-02	Project folder archived	PM	1 d	X-01	Project file marked as closed (<i>p.39</i>)	NEW	

#	Milestone	Owner	Dur.	Depends on	Evidence that closes it	Today	Notes / correction
X-03	FINAL PAYMENT RECEIVED	Financial Mgr	30-90 d	I-07	Payment recorded with invoice number and amount (<i>p.39</i>)	NEW	
X-04	Final P&L issued	CFO	5 d	X-03	Project P&L report (<i>p.39</i>)	NEW	

X-03 formally closes the project. The only milestone after physical delivery, with its own clock: measured against the contract payment terms, with collection alerts once overdue.

The 8 hard gates

The points where the system **blocks** progress until its requirements are met. This is where the real control lives — not in the reports.

Gate	Requires	Consequence if unmet	Notes / correction
C-03 · Contract executed	C-02	The clock does not start. Alert before it comes due	
E-09 · MTO released	Shop drawings approved (E-07)	Purchasing cannot quote	
E-10 · Release to Production	Approved and stamped drawings (E-07)	Production cannot open	
P-01 · Production Intake	Samples approved + drawings approved + release + CNC + material 100%	Production does not start	
QC-02 · Final QC	Fabrication complete	Cannot package	
S-02 · Delivery request	48 hours' notice	Logistics cannot confirm a truck	
I-03 · Site ready	GC confirmation	Installation does not start — delay attributed to the GC	
I-06 · Punch list	Every item photographed	No sign-off and no final payment	

Risk model

Status	Meaning
GREEN	Float $\geq$ 3 working days
YELLOW	Float between 0 and 3 days
RED	Negative float: already eating into the delivery date
GRAY	Not yet applicable (predecessors unmet)

Risk management as a discipline. Each phase has a schedule-review milestone (E-12 in Engineering, M-01 in Procurement) whose explicit purpose is to **verify whether the deadline can be met**. It is the operational face of the two-clocks model: it does not wait for the delay, it anticipates it.

Attribution of lost days

Every milestone that closes late records who the delay belongs to:

Client · GC · Vendor · Estimating · Engineering · Procurement · Production ·

Logistics · Field · Finance

That running total is the report that answers “**why do we deliver late?**” at year end with numbers instead of opinions — and it is the documented argument in front of GCs and clients.

Warning: the first report will be uncomfortable. It is a diagnosis of the process, not a control on people.

Current instrumentation status

How much of the journey the system can measure today, without building anything new.

Phase	Milestones	Have	Partial	To build
1 · Contract	9	0	1	8
2 · Engineering	12	1	2	9
3 · Materials	7	4	0	3
4 · Production	6	2	1	3
5 · QC	3	3	0	0
6 · Shipping	5	0	1	4
7 · Install	7	0	1	6
8 · Completed	4	0	0	4
TOTAL	53	10	6	37

Engineering counts the 12 main milestones; E-01 additionally has 5 sub-tasks.

~19% of the journey is instrumented today, concentrated in the middle — Materials, Production and QC. Both ends, where the weeks are lost, are new ground.

The underlying implication: the system can only measure what happens inside it. Estimating, Engineering, Logistics and Field work outside it today — Excel, Pytha, Bluebeam, Smartsheets, Pipedrive, OneDrive, email. **The core decision is not technical: it is whether that work moves into the system.**

The 3-Week Lookahead form

Today the PM builds it by hand every week. In the system **it generates itself**, from data it already has.

Column	Where it comes from
Project # / Name / Client	projects
Items	MTO / PO items

Includes **Sample Requests** as their own rows.

Why it is achievable now

Column	Where it comes from
Millwork (quantity)	item total quantity
Progress %	progress by station (kiosk) — counted
To fabricate	total – completed
Due Date	item deadline (from the schedule)
Priority (1/2/3/Samples)	item priority, color-coded
Comments	item notes
Week 1 / 2 / 3	quantity to fabricate each week

All of that data exists or is derived from what the app tracks today (projects, items, progress by station, due dates). It is one of the first things to come out of the engine, and it **replaces a weekly manual task for the PM**.

Client portal

Tokenized link access, one per contact — no accounts to create. Every action is attributed to a specific person.

The client can

- See their project timeline by milestone, with status and dates
- See what the project is waiting on **and who holds the ball**
- **Approve / approve as noted / reject:** shop drawings, samples, V/E, early procurement
- Give the **final sign-off**
- See fabrication and installation progress photos
- Download contract, approved drawings, BOL, shipping list

Automatic to the client

“Shop drawings have been under review for 12 days. Each additional day pushes the October 15 delivery.”

Turns the “waiting on the client” black hole into a data point with a date, a time and an owner. **The client does NOT see** costs, margins, budgets, vendors or pricing.

Build roadmap

Six stages. Each one stands on its own and delivers value even if the project pauses. Estimated at the current pace, with no dedicated development team.

#	Stage	What it includes	Duration	What it delivers	Notes
1	Schedule engine + 3WLA	Working calendar, milestone template, backward calculation, dependencies, float, status, delay attribution, project timeline, auto-generated 3-Week Lookahead form	3-5 wks	The schedule is live, fed by Materials + Production + QC. The PM stops building the 3WLA by hand	
2	Client portal	Tokenized links, public timeline, dated approvals, automatic reminders, progress photos	3-4 wks	Closes the approvals black hole. E-05, E-07, I-07 become hard data	
3	Engineering	Submittals, shop drawing versions and revisions, CNC files, release to production, MTO release, VIF, risk management	6-8 wks	The largest phase, and the one that exposes the most delay. Closes the full P-01 gate	
4	Field, Shipping & Install	BOL, load photos and seal, delivery request, on-site check-in, installation progress, punch list — all on mobile	4-6 wks	The journey is closed end to end, through to sign-off	
5	Contract intake	Contract execution, deposit (non-blocking), preliminary MTO validated, budget validated, announcement, kickoff, POC handoff	3-4 wks	The project is born in the system with its target date and its feasibility	
6	Financial closeout	Budget by area, milestone billing, collections, final payment, P&L. QuickBooks integration	4-6 wks	The project closes formally where it should close	
	TOTAL		23-33 wks	Between 6 and 8 months of effective work	

Why this order

- Stage 1 starts **where the data already exists**, and the 3WLA gives immediate value
- Stage 2 is **the largest gain for the least code**
- Stage 3 is the biggest, and lands once the engine is proven
- Stage 5 (Contract intake) comes late because the schedule already works starting from the contract, even if its entry is manual at first

Project risks

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Adoption by the office areas	Critical	Every capture must be a by-product of the work. Explicit leadership backing. Without it, dies at stage 3
Resistance to being measured	High	Present attribution as a diagnosis of the process, not a control on people

Honest warning: the estimate assumes consistency. If interrupted for weeks to handle production, it stretches. And it does not include **adoption** time, which in the office areas may weigh more than the development itself.

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Months without visible value	High	This is why stage 1 delivers schedule + 3WLA in 3-5 weeks
Building a document management system	Medium	It is not one. File + date + version. Bluebeam and Pytha remain the working tools
Poorly calibrated durations	Medium	Correct them in this review. Recalibrate against history from month six
The system becomes heavy to use	Medium	No milestone may require more than one action. If it requires two, the design is wrong

What this review needs to produce

- ☐ **Durations.** The ones in this document are estimates. Correct them with each area's owner.
- ☐ **Owners.** The official document names 13 roles; the system today has 9 and they do not match. They need to be mapped.
- ☐ **Milestones that are missing, unnecessary, or that don't work this way in practice.**
- ☐ **Granularity.** Per item / area with rollup to the project (defined) — validate against this map.
- ☐ **Working calendar.** Working days, Central Millwork holidays, shutdown weeks.
- ☐ **Phased delivery.** Projects delivered by floor or by area with separate dates.
- ☐ **Projects without installation.** The document contemplates them (p.37). The chain would close at S-04.
- ☐ **Change orders.** The milestone was removed from the journey in Rev 1; how they impact the target date still needs defining.

Closing note. This map does not invent a process: it transcribes the one Central Millwork already has written down, and turns it into something the system can calculate. What is missing is not the idea — it is that this schedule stops living in a spreadsheet nobody updates and starts finding out what is actually happening.